

109 Zerubbabel

The prince of David's line who led the exiles home and rebuilt the temple, "not by might, nor by power."

Zerubbabel, a grandson of King Jehoiachin, led the first large group of exiles home with Jeshua the high priest. Together they rebuilt the altar and laid the foundation of a new temple, while old men wept and the young shouted for joy. Then opposition stopped the work for about sixteen years. In 520 BC Haggai and Zechariah stirred him to begin again, and God promised his hands would finish it. The temple was completed in 516/515 BC. He appears in both family lines of Jesus, a sign that God kept David's line alive through the exile.

At a glance

Name	Probably Babylonian, often explained as "seed of Babylon"
Family	Son of Shealtiel, grandson of Jehoiachin (Ezra 3:2; 1 Chr 3:17-19)
Role	Governor of Judah under the Persians (Haggai 1:1)
When	Returned c. 538/537 BC; temple finished 516/515 BC
Key people	Jeshua (Joshua) the high priest, Haggai, Zechariah, Darius
Main passages	Ezra 2-6; Haggai 1-2; Zechariah 4
New Testament	"Zorobabel" in Jesus' family lines (Matt 1:12-13; Luke 3:27)

"Not by might, nor by power, but by my spirit, saith the LORD of hosts."

Zechariah 4:6, KJV

The life of Zerubbabel

Dates approximate (BC): a start under Cyrus, a long delay, completion under Darius
I. Chronicles lists Zerubbabel as a son of Pedaiah, Shealtiel's brother.

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| c. 538/537 BC
<i>After Cyrus's decree</i> | <p>● Leads the exiles home</p> <p>Zerubbabel heads the leaders who return from Babylon. The company numbers 42,360, besides 7,337 servants. <i>Ezra 2:1-2, 64-67</i></p> |
| c. 537/536 BC
<i>7th month</i> | <p>● The altar rebuilt</p> <p>With Jeshua he rebuilds the altar, and daily sacrifices begin again, though the people fear their neighbours. <i>Ezra 3:1-6</i></p> |
| c. 536 BC
<i>2nd year</i> | <p>● The foundation laid</p> <p>Priests blow trumpets; many shout for joy, while old men who saw the first temple weep aloud. <i>Ezra 3:8-13</i></p> |
| c. 536-520 BC
<i>Years of delay</i> | <p>● Work stops</p> <p>He refuses help from the local peoples, who then frighten the builders and hire counsellors against them. <i>Ezra 4:1-5, 24</i></p> |
| c. 520 BC
<i>Darius's 2nd year</i> | <p>● Back to work</p> <p>Haggai rebukes the people for neglecting God's house. Zerubbabel, Joshua and the people obey and begin again. <i>Haggai 1:1-15; Ezra 5:1-2</i></p> |
| c. 520 BC
<i>9th month</i> | <p>● God's signet</p> <p>God promises to make Zerubbabel "as a signet." Zechariah adds that his hands will finish the house. <i>Haggai 2:20-23; Zechariah 4:6-10</i></p> |
| c. 516/515 BC
<i>Darius's 6th year</i> | <p>● The temple finished</p> <p>The house is dedicated with joy. Zerubbabel is not named there, and his later life is not recorded. <i>Ezra 6:14-16</i></p> |

Key activities

Ezra 5:16 says that Sheshbazzar laid the temple's foundation, while Ezra 3 and Zechariah 4:9 credit Zerubbabel. Some think they were the same man with two names. Others think Sheshbazzar was the first governor and Zerubbabel led the actual work.

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- 1 Led the first return.** He is named first among the leaders who brought the exiles home. *Ezra 2:1-2*

 - 2 Put worship first.** Before any walls or houses, he helped rebuild the altar and restore the daily offerings. *Ezra 3:2-6*

 - 3 Laid the foundation.** He organised the Levites to oversee the work and led the celebration. *Ezra 3:8-11*

 - 4 Refused a compromise.** He told the local peoples, "Ye have nothing to do with us to build an house unto our God." *Ezra 4:1-3*

 - 5 Obeyed God's word.** When Haggai spoke, Zerubbabel, Joshua and the people "obeyed the voice of the LORD their God." *Haggai 1:12-14*

 - 6 Took courage.** God told him, "be strong, O Zerubbabel ... for I am with you." *Haggai 2:4*

 - 7 Finished the work.** The temple rose in spite of an official inquiry, completing what his hands had begun. *Ezra 5:2-5; 6:14-15; Zechariah 4:9*

Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Zerubbabel.

Old Testament

Ezra 2:2; 3:2, 8; 4:2–3; 5:2	He leads the return and the rebuilding
Nehemiah 7:7; 12:1, 47	Remembered as leader of the first return
1 Chronicles 3:17–19	In David's royal line through Jehoiachin
Haggai 1:1, 12, 14; 2:2, 4, 21–23	Governor and God's chosen signet
Zechariah 4:6–10	"Not by might, nor by power, but by my spirit"
Echo: Zechariah 4:14	"Two anointed ones," often taken as Zerubbabel and Joshua

New Testament

Matthew 1:12–13; Luke 3:27	"Zorobabel," ancestor of Jesus in both lines
Echo: 1 Corinthians 3:10–11	The foundation "which is Jesus Christ"

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What did Zerubbabel and Jeshua build first, and why do you think they started there (Ezra 3:1–6)?
2. *Understand:* Why would God say "Not by might, nor by power, but by my spirit" to a man leading a building project?
3. *Apply:* Zerubbabel's work stalled for sixteen years. Is there something God gave you to do that you have set aside? What would restarting look like?
4. *Apply:* Some wept because the new temple looked small. Where are you tempted to despise "the day of small things"?